Industrial organization

The doctor is looking at me with a serious expression. His brow is furrowed, jaws slightly clenched, his shoulders tense. He *looks* serious enough, that's for sure, yet it just doesn't *feel* quite right. The hands clasped on the desk, the way he compresses his lips as if to purge them of any potentially inappropriate color, it's all too practiced, too performed. In fact, despite the topic of our current conversation, I think the doctor is in a perfectly fine mood. I think he is a happy man who works hard, on my behalf, to put on this serious face and I guess that's something I should appreciate. And why wouldn't he be happy and in a fine mood? He's handsome, wealthy, successful, and rich, and tall and healthy, and respected and he has a secretary and a big office and he's not about to die, and he's rich. But I neither am nor have any of those things, and so he must suppress his joy and furrow his brow and purse his lips while saying things like: "*Unfortunately, the treatment hasn't delivered the results we hoped for*" and "*I'm afraid we're running out of options… at least within your range*." Again he tells me I need to rest more and again I explain I actually need extra shifts to afford even the current treatment. His eyes are narrower now, his whole face appears oddly stiff, almost frozen. I bite my lip as I realize I'm rubbing the bottom button of my coat again, already conspicuously polished compared to its neighbors. He steals a look at the clock above the door, lets out a soft sigh and sits back in his chair, the movement momentarily dislodging a single strand of gold from his perfectly sculpted hair. We sit in silence for a moment. Suddenly, his eyes snap back to me, he deftly threads the rebellious lock back into place, and a sliver of pink appears within the slightest of smiles.

– You know, at its core, your issue is one of scale.

– Of scale?

– Yes. Or scope, if you prefer. See, a body is an expensive commodity. It's difficult to run one all by yourself and, frankly, if things keep going the way they are, yours doesn't have long left.

– Well, that's why I'm here, isn't it?

– Yes, yes, of course, my point is that it's inefficient for us to sit here week after week, one-on-one, and for you to struggle and slave just to waste it all on low-tier medications and treatments which will never fix your fundamental issue of scale. Or scope, if you prefer.

– I'm not sure I understand, of course I'd prefer the higher-tier treatments. If I could get some support from the state or-

– No no no, you don't need 'support' from a teat like a helpless newborn! We'd only be feeding your inefficiency, not treating it. No, what you need is a merger.

– A merger?

– Think about it, just today I have to face at least ten other patients in your position. I have to sit here and go through the same spiel and take what little money they have and tomorrow there's a hundred of you and the day after and the next until you are back again and the merry-go-round goes round and round and for what? What's the end-goal here? Keeping all these people just barely alive day after day for as long as we can? It's wasteful. Wasteful, and unnecessary.

– What are you talking about? What do you want? To get rid of me? Kill all the poor and be done?

– Christ, no! I'm a doctor! You may not believe me when I tell you, but I do care. I care deeply about your well-being – not just the health to pass you over to tomorrow, but your overall well-being. What I'm talking about here is looking past the symptoms to the root*, the rot, the inefficiencies.*

It's as if the doctor has cast off some heavy burden, shed his thick skin of pretense. Now he paces around the office with gleaming eyes and a radiant smile. He pulls a surprisingly large, rusty key from his starched white coat pocket and turns to the ornate wooden chest in the corner (which, until now, had always felt out of place in the otherwise normal doctor's office). He throws it open and pulls out a thick, ancient-looking book bound in cracked black leather. He raises his voice slightly as the yellowed pages seem to cry and wail in whispered voices when he aggressively snaps through them.

– The operation is simple, quick, and not too painful. And we're talking mergers here, not even acquisitions, so it's between two consenting adults. It would be unethical not *to share the solution with you!*

– Acquisitions?

– Not yet, we'll keep it as a back-up but I'm glad you're finally keeping up. No, just a simple innocent merger. Here.

He places the heavy tome upright on the table with a thud. Facing me is a convoluted illustration of human bodies covered in cryptic symbols, overlaid with diagrams, equations, and text in a language I don't recognize.

– Your current issue is your heart. But your body is so much more than just one lousy heart! Your lungs, your spleen, your brain – your other departments are doing some great work! For that all to go to waste due to a single faulty part? Ridiculous!

– Sure, but you say I cannot afford the proper treatment!

– Exactly! And why not? Because you need too much – your costs are exorbitant! And there are far too many others like you who also need it and so you compete each other deep down into the red. The model is simply not sustainable. Sure, I could give you some xylioephilin and a pack of rado and your heart would probably improve. But if it's just to send you right back out into the dogfight? That would be a cruelty, not a kindness.

He pauses for a breath, composing himself. The serious expression is back, this time I believe it. My time is up, but this is the first time I feel his undivided attention, so I stay silent and try to understand.

– Thankfully, it doesn't have to be this way. Take my next patient. She has some corruption in her stomach, terrible stuff. She used to have a good job, but she can't work anymore, she can't eat, she can't move, can't do anything. Still, I have to see her and dump resources into that black hole day after day to keep the husk going. But her heart is fine, just fine – and she's pretty too. You see what I'm saying? The money's on the ground – you just have to pick it up.

– I should… take her heart?

– Again, great enthusiasm, but let's keep the acquisition as back-up. Just a clean, simple merger. Meet with her, discuss what you like and what you dislike in yourself and each other, negotiate! Strong heart, healthy tummy, pretty face, good job, etc. etc. Identify each other's comparative advantages. Keep the top-earners, trim the fat. We can go beyond the survival of the fittest whole *to the survival of the fittest* parts *– this is the natural next step for us! Half the cost, double the experience, double the well-being!*

– Her face? You've lost your mind! What would become of me?

– No, no! My mind is the one thing I've kept! Don't you see? What would become of you is something greater. Don't you wish to get out of this hellish whirlpool you're stuck in? To become sustainable? Now it's your heart, but even if you had the money to fix it, how long can your kidneys maintain full performance? How long can your liver keep delivering these numbers? I told you, I have hundreds of people in here every week! You're fighting for crumbs like rats in a cage when you should be joining forces.

While he speaks I stay silent and begin to understand. His thick, golden hair, his gleaming eyes and radiant smile, his immaculate face, his tall, muscular frame, his intelligence, his wealth, his success, his health. How many are they?

– You simply won't ever get anywhere unless you restructure. I'm offering you a straight-forward, scalable, data-driven process to restructure into a lean, sustainable, highly-productive joint-enterprise through corporal transformation. It's a win-win! Of course, I'll require a small consultancy fee for my services rendered, but since you'll be paying out of two pockets it's really a no-brainer. In the end, it's practically two for the price of one.